
Content Radar

A done-for-you AI workflow that finds trending posts in your niche and turns them into ranked short-form video ideas.

What this guide will get you set up to do

Run one workflow → get 10 ranked video ideas every time, with hooks, scripts, business value, and an explanation of why each idea will work — all in your chosen language, all in one Google Sheet.

In this guide

1. What you need before starting
2. Step 1 — Set up your Google Sheet
3. Step 2 — Get your API credentials
4. Step 3 — Import the workflow into n8n
5. Step 4 — Connect everything together
6. Step 5 — Run it for the first time
7. Customizing for your niche
8. Troubleshooting
9. Optional — Telegram notifications
10. Quick reference card

What you need before starting

Before importing anything, make sure you have accounts for the four services this workflow uses. None of these are optional except Telegram. If you don't have one, the link below tells you where to sign up.

Service	What it does	Cost
n8n	Runs the workflow itself	Free self-host or \$20/mo cloud
Apify	Scrapes posts from X, Instagram, TikTok, YouTube	Free \$5/month credit, then pay-per-use
OpenAI	Generates the ranked video ideas	Pay-per-use, ~\$0.02–0.10 per run
Google Sheets	Stores your config, raw posts, and final ideas	Free
Telegram (optional)	Sends a summary message after each run	Free

Realistic cost

For a typical run scraping 600 posts and generating 10 ideas, you'll spend around **\$0.10–0.30 in Apify credits** and **\$0.05–0.15 in OpenAI**. Run it daily for a month and you're looking at \$5–15 total.

You'll also need the two files this guide came with:

- `Content_Radar_Workflow.json` — the n8n workflow
- `Content_Radar.xlsx` — the spreadsheet template

STEP 1 OF 5

Set up your Google Sheet

The spreadsheet is where you tell the workflow what to look for, and where all the results land. We'll start here because the next steps need a sheet URL to point to.

1.1 Upload the template to Google Drive

Open Google Drive in your browser, click **+ New** → **File upload**, and select the `Content_Radar.xlsx` file you got.

1.2 Open it as a Google Sheet

Once uploaded, double-click the file to preview it, then click **Open with** → **Google Sheets** at the top. Google will create a Sheets version. Bookmark the URL — you'll paste it 6 times in Step 4.

1.3 Verify the 6 tabs are there

At the bottom you should see these tabs:

- **README** — quick instructions
- **Config** — **this is the only tab you'll edit**
- **Raw_Posts** — every post the workflow scrapes (auto-filled)
- **Filtered_Posts** — top 20 viral signals per run (auto-filled)
- **AI_Content_Ideas** — your final ideas (auto-filled, this is the gold)
- **System_Log** — run history and errors (auto-filled)

1.4 Look at the Config tab

Click the **Config** tab. Row 2 is already pre-filled with sensible defaults for an AI/automation niche. You can leave it as-is for your first run, or edit the values now. Each column does this:

Field	What it does
niche_name	Your brand framing (e.g. 'AI for solopreneurs', 'Fitness for moms over 40')
keywords	Comma-separated words. Used for X search + YouTube search
hashtags_x	Comma-separated, no #. Each becomes a #hashtag query on X
hashtags_instagram	Comma-separated, no #. Each hits Instagram's explore/tags page
hashtags_tiktok	Comma-separated, no #. TikTok hashtag mode
hashtags_youtube	Comma-separated, no #. Each hits /hashtag/X/shorts
language_output	What language the AI writes ideas in (english, romanian, french, etc.)
min_views	View threshold for the engagement bar. Default 5000
time_window_days	How fresh posts must be to count. Default 5
platforms	Which platforms to scrape (any of: x, instagram, tiktok, youtube)

Don't overthink the Config

If you're not sure what to put yet, leave row 2 alone. The defaults work. Run it once, see what comes out, then tweak. Tighter hashtags = more on-brand results. Broader hashtags = more results overall.

STEP 2 OF 5

Get your API credentials

You'll grab three credentials. Each takes 1–2 minutes. Keep them somewhere safe (a password manager, or a private note) — you'll paste them into n8n in Step 4.

2.1 Apify token

- Go to apify.com and sign up (free).

- In the left sidebar, click **Settings** → **API & Integrations**.
- Copy your **Personal API token** — it starts with `apify_api_`
- Save it. You'll paste this once in n8n and all 4 scrapers use the same token.

About Apify pricing

New accounts get \$5 in free credit, which is enough for ~50 runs of this workflow. After that, expect ~\$0.10–\$0.30 per full run depending on how many platforms and hashtags you've configured.

2.2 OpenAI API key

- Go to platform.openai.com and sign in.
- Click your profile (top right) → **View API keys** → **Create new secret key**.
- Copy the key — it starts with `sk-proj-` or `sk-`
- Save it. You can only see this key once — if you lose it, create a new one.

Make sure you have credits

OpenAI requires a paid account with credits added. Go to **Settings** → **Billing** and add at least \$5. The workflow uses GPT-4o by default, which costs roughly \$0.05–0.15 per run.

2.3 Google Sheets — handled in n8n

Google Sheets uses OAuth, which is set up directly inside n8n in Step 4. You don't need to grab anything in advance — just have your Google account ready to log into when n8n asks.

STEP 3 OF 5

Import the workflow into n8n

If you don't have an n8n instance yet, sign up at n8n.cloud for the easy path. Self-hosting works the same way once you're logged in.

3.1 Open the import dialog

- In n8n, click **Workflows** in the left sidebar.
- Click the **+** in the top right → **Import from File**.
- Select your `Content_Radar_Workflow.json` file.

3.2 Save it immediately

Once the workflow opens, hit **Cmd/Ctrl + S** or click **Save** in the top right. Give it a name like "Content Radar". This locks it in before you start configuring nodes.

What you'll see

Around 41 nodes laid out in a left-to-right flow: trigger → config → fan out to 4 platforms → merge → score → send to AI → save ideas. Don't be overwhelmed — you only need to touch about 10 of them.

STEP 4 OF 5**Connect everything together**

This is the longest step — 10–15 minutes — but it's just clicking through nodes and pasting credentials. We'll go in 3 passes: credentials, then sheet URL, then sheet tabs.

4.1 Set up the credentials (3 types)

On any node with a yellow warning triangle, click it open. At the top you'll see a **Credential to connect with** field. Click it → **Create new credential**. Set up each of these once:

- **Apify Token** (Header Auth credential): paste `Authorization` as the header name and `Bearer YOUR_APIFY_TOKEN` as the value.
- **OpenAI**: paste your `sk- . . .` key.
- **Google Sheets**: click **Sign in with Google**, pick the account that owns your sheet, allow access. n8n handles the rest.

4.2 Apply credentials to every node

Once each credential exists, the dropdown in every other node of that type will show it. Open each node, pick the credential, save. You'll do this for:

- **6 Google Sheets nodes** (Read Config, Load Existing Raw Posts, Save Raw Posts, Save Filtered Posts, Save AI Content Ideas, Append to System_Log)
- **4 Apify HTTP nodes** (Scrape X, Scrape Instagram, Scrape TikTok, Scrape YouTube)
- **1 OpenAI node** (AI Agent: Generate Content Ideas)

4.3 Paste your Sheet URL into all 6 Sheets nodes

Each Google Sheets node has a **Document** field. Currently it says `REPLACE_WITH_YOUR_SHEET_URL`. Replace it with your actual sheet URL (the one you bookmarked in Step 1).

Pro tip — copy once, paste 6 times

Open one Sheets node, paste your URL, save. Then for each remaining one, open it, click the document field, paste the same URL. Should take ~2 minutes total.

4.4 Pick the right tab in each Sheets node

Below the Document field is the **Sheet** field — pick the right tab from the dropdown for each node:

Node	Pick this tab
Read Config	Config
Load Existing Raw Posts	Raw_Posts
Save Raw Posts	Raw_Posts
Save Filtered Posts	Filtered_Posts
Save AI Content Ideas	AI_Content_Ideas
Append to System_Log	System_Log

4.5 One special toggle

Open the **Load Existing Raw Posts** node. Click the **Settings** tab at the top. Find **Always Output Data** and toggle it ON. Save. This prevents the workflow from halting on your very first run when the Raw_Posts sheet is empty.

STEP 5 OF 5

Run it for the first time

5.1 Click Execute Workflow

At the bottom of the n8n canvas, click the big **Execute Workflow** button. Watch the nodes light up one after another in green.

5.2 What's happening

- **0–10 sec**: reads your Config, fans out to enabled platforms
- **10 sec – 4 min**: 4 scrapers run in parallel via Apify (TikTok and IG are usually fastest, YouTube is slowest)
- **4 min – 5 min**: scoring, filtering, AI generates 10 video ideas
- **5 min**: writes everything to your sheet, you're done

5.3 Check your AI_Content_Ideas tab

Open your Google Sheet → **AI_Content_Ideas** tab. You should see 6 columns:

Column	What it is
idea_title	The video idea, in one line
business_value	Practical value for the audience

<code>why_it_works</code>	Why this idea will perform — tied to real signals
<code>hook_ro</code>	The opening line of the video (in your chosen language)
<code>script_angle_ro</code>	How to structure or film the video
<code>avg_views</code>	Average views of the source post(s) the idea was based on

Note about the column names

`hook_ro` and `script_angle_ro` have an `_ro` suffix from a legacy version. They get filled in your chosen language regardless — Romanian, English, French, whatever you set.

Customizing for your niche

Once it's running, you don't need to touch n8n again. All the customization happens in row 2 of the Config tab.

Switching to a different niche

Just edit the Config row. Some examples:

Niche	<code>niche_name</code>	keywords (sample)	<code>hashtags_tiktok</code>
Fitness	Fitness for busy parents	home workout, no equipment, 10 min workout	homeworkout, fitnessmom, busyparents
Cooking	Quick weeknight dinners	30 minute meals, sheet pan, weeknight dinner	easyrecipes, weeknightdinner, mealprep
Real estate	First-time home buyer tips	first home, mortgage, home inspection	realestate, firsttimebuyer, househunting

Switching languages

Change `language_output` in your Config tab. Any common language works: english, romanian, french, spanish, german, italian, portuguese, polish, etc. The AI writes `idea_title`, `hook`, `script`, `why_it_works`, and `business_value` in that language.

Tightening or widening the funnel

- **Want more posts to choose from?** Lower `min_views` from 5000 to 2000 or 1000.
- **Want fresher content only?** Lower `time_window_days` from 5 to 2 or 3.
- **Want fewer platforms?** Remove platforms from the `platforms` field. e.g. just "x, instagram" skips TikTok and YouTube.

Troubleshooting

These are the issues that come up most often, in roughly the order you'll hit them.

The workflow stops at "Load Existing Raw Posts"

Open that node → Settings tab → toggle **Always Output Data** ON. This happens because the Raw_Posts sheet is empty on your first run and n8n's default behavior is to halt when a node returns zero items.

"AI returned non-parseable output" or AI Agent error

Two common causes. First, check your OpenAI account has credits (platform.openai.com → Billing). Second, if you're using GPT-5 family models, increase the **maxTokens** in the AI Agent node options to 16000 or higher — reasoning models eat tokens before producing output. Easier fix: switch the model to GPT-4o.

Only 3 ideas appear, all marked "needs_review"

This means none of the AI's ideas scored 70+ on quality. Either trust those 3 (they really are the best of the batch), or open **Filter & Rank Ideas** and lower the threshold from 70 to 60 or 50. Better long-term fix: tighten your Config hashtags so more on-brand content gets scraped.

Ideas appear in row 28+ instead of row 2

Your sheet has invisible ghost rows from formatting. Select rows 2 through 27, right-click → **Delete rows** (not Clear contents — actually Delete). Next run will append starting at row 2.

YouTube branch stays grey

Expected if `youtube` isn't in your Config's platforms field. To enable: edit Config row 2 → platforms column → add youtube to the list (e.g. `x, instagram, tiktok, youtube`).

Final ideas are in the wrong language

Check `language_output` in your Config tab — make sure it's spelled correctly and lowercase. "english" works, "English " with a trailing space does not.

Apify scraper times out

One platform is slow. YouTube takes the longest (up to 9 minutes). If a scraper consistently times out, check the run on the Apify console (console.apify.com) to see what actually happened. The HTTP node timeout in n8n can be increased if needed.

"Sheet not found" error in any Google Sheets node

The sheet URL is wrong or the dropdown lost its tab selection. Open the node, paste the correct URL again, then re-pick the tab from the Sheet dropdown.

Optional — Telegram notifications

If you want a Telegram message after each run with a summary of how many ideas were generated and what the top one was, here's how:

Create a Telegram bot

- In Telegram, search for **@BotFather**, message it /newbot
- Follow prompts to name your bot. BotFather sends you a token like 1234567890:ABCdef . . . Save it.
- Send any message to your new bot from your Telegram account. This is required to get a chat_id.
- Get your chat_id: visit https://api.telegram.org/bot<YOUR_TOKEN>/getUpdates in your browser, find "chat": {"id": . . . } in the response.

Wire it up in n8n

- Open the **Send Telegram Summary** node (it's at the very end, currently disabled).
- Click **Create new credential**, paste your bot token.
- In the Chat ID field, replace `REPLACE_WITH_TELEGRAM_CHAT_ID` with your chat_id.
- In the Settings tab, toggle off **Disabled**. Save.

Quick reference card

The 5-minute version. Print this page, stick it on your wall.

Setup checklist

- [] Upload Content_Radar.xlsx to Drive, open as Google Sheet
- [] Sign up for Apify, copy API token

- [] Sign up for OpenAI, add credits, copy API key
- [] Import Content_Radar_Workflow.json into n8n
- [] Create 3 credentials in n8n: Apify (Header Auth), OpenAI, Google Sheets (OAuth)
- [] Apply credentials to all 11 nodes that need them (6 Sheets, 4 Apify, 1 OpenAI)
- [] Paste sheet URL into all 6 Google Sheets nodes
- [] Pick the right tab in each Sheets node (see Step 4.4)
- [] Toggle Always Output Data ON in Load Existing Raw Posts
- [] Edit Config row 2 if you want a different niche (or skip and use defaults)
- [] Click Execute Workflow

Defaults (Config row 2)

Field	Default
niche_name	AI for solopreneurs
language_output	english
min_views	5000
time_window_days	5
platforms	x, instagram, tiktok

Most common gotchas

- **Workflow halts at Load Existing Raw Posts on first run** → toggle Always Output Data
- **Only 3 "needs_review" ideas** → AI scored everything below 70. Trust them or lower the threshold
- **Rows appearing way down the sheet** → ghost rows. Delete (not Clear) the empty rows
- **AI Agent error** → check OpenAI credits, or switch model to GPT-4o
- **One platform stays grey** → it's not in your Config's platforms field

You're done. Run it once a day, once a week, or whenever. The Config tab is the only thing you'll touch from here on. New niche? Edit Config. New language? Edit Config. The workflow does the rest.